

Impact: High Difficulty: Hard Misuse risk: Low

CORE FORMULA

Make the point -> Stop -> Wait -> Add one sentence only if pressed

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

After making your point, stop before adding another sentence. Sit in the silence. If you feel the pull to add more, resist it for five seconds.

BEST FOR

- Any communication under pressure or scrutiny
- Presenting to senior audiences
- Answering interview or viva-style questions
- Avoiding defensive spirals when challenged

PHRASE BANK

Stopping Phrases · Signals that you are done

- "That is my position."
- "I will leave it there."
- "Happy to expand if that would help."
- "That is the short version."
- "I could say more — I think that is the main point though."
- "Let me stop there and see if you have questions."
- "That is it."

Recovery Stops · Catching yourself mid-over-explain

- "Actually — I am over-explaining. The point is simply: ..."
- "Let me stop there. I was adding too much."
- "I have made the point. Let me leave it."
- "I tend to add too much. The actual point is: ..."
- "Let me cut that down: ..."

Professional Full Stops · Ending cleanly in work settings

- "That is the update. Questions welcome."
- "Nothing further from me unless you want detail."
- "I will pause there — where would you like to go deeper?"
- "That covers the decision. The appendix has the rest."
- "I have one point and I have made it."

Holding the Stop · When scrutiny tempts you to keep talking

- "That is my answer. I am comfortable with it."
- "I have given you my reasoning. I will let it stand."
- "I do not have more to add — not because I am unsure, but because that is the whole point."
- "I would rather leave a clear point than bury it in defence."
- "If there is a specific gap, ask me — otherwise that is my position."

Warm Stops · Brevity that stays kind

- "That is the honest answer, short as it is."
- "I will leave it there — tell me if you want the longer story."
- "Short answer, said with love: no."

- "That is all I meant — nothing hidden behind it."
- "I am keeping it brief because it is simple, not because I do not care."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Three paragraphs where one sentence would have worked
Better: Here is the answer — there are three reasons behind it...
Best: One sentence answer. Then silence. Add detail only if asked.
2. Weak: Restating your point three different ways
Better: I want to make sure I am being clear — ...
Best: State it once, clearly. Trust it landed. Stop.
3. Weak: Adding qualifiers and caveats that dilute the point
Better: There are a few caveats worth noting.
Best: Make the point. Add one caveat only if essential. Stop.

DECISION TREE

If You have made your point and feel the urge to add more

Notice the urge. Pause. Say nothing. See if they respond.

If They look confused after your point

Ask a clarifying question rather than adding more explanation.

"Does that answer the question, or would a different angle help?"

If You catch yourself mid-over-explain

Stop. Name it. Restate the core point.

"Let me cut that down — the actual answer is: ..."

If They press for more detail

Now you can add — but one sentence at a time, then stop again.

"The one detail I would add is..."

If You over-explain because you are nervous

Slow down. The over-explaining is coming from pressure — not from the content needing more.

"I want to answer that directly. The answer is: ..."

SCENARIOS

Answering an interview question

Answer in two sentences. Pause. Let the interviewer respond. — "My experience in X has been Y. That is the core of it."

Presenting a recommendation to a senior person

Give the recommendation. One reason. Stop. — "I recommend X. The main reason is Y."

Being challenged on a decision

Defend once, clearly. Do not add defences on top of defences. — "The reason I made that call was X. I am happy to discuss it."

Explaining yourself after a misunderstanding

Say what you meant once. Resist the urge to keep justifying. — "What I meant was X. That is the full version."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the audience genuinely needs context to evaluate your position — brevity without context can feel dismissive.
- In teaching situations where the explanation is the entire value.
- When legal, medical, or safety contexts require thorough disclosure regardless of length.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Notice the urge

In one conversation today, notice every moment when you want to add more after you have made your point. Do not change anything — just notice.

Day 2 — Stop after one sentence

In three exchanges today, stop after one sentence answer and wait.

Day 3 — The pause test

After making your main point, pause for three full seconds before adding anything else.

Day 4 — Catch mid-over-explain

Practise the recovery: 'Let me cut that down — the point is: ...' Use it once today.

Day 5 — Two-sentence limit

Set a self-imposed limit of two sentences for answers to direct questions. Notice the effect.

Day 6 — High-pressure context

Use this in a meeting or presentation where you would normally over-explain.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did your communication land better? Did anyone ask for more detail? Did any brevity feel underpowered?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I make my point and stop — without adding another sentence?
- Did I resist the urge to restate the same point three different ways?
- Did I avoid adding qualifiers that diluted the point?
- Did I wait to see if they asked for more before explaining further?
- Did I catch myself over-explaining and self-correct?
- Did I trust that my point had landed rather than re-explaining it?
- Did I keep my energy and tone steady rather than speeding up with more words?